The Assets Safehouse

PADMAJA CHUNDURU'S CAREER started as a probationary officer in the State Bank of India (SBI) in 1984, but by the early 2000s she was heading the bank's operations in the US. Which is why she advises youngsters to "never let go of an opportunity". "Things do work out. I took a posting in SBI Los Angeles in 2001 and had to manage alone for four years with my two sons but it paid off later," she says.

Padmaja Chunduru, *62*
MD and CEO, NSDL

Padmaja went on to become the deputy MD at the country's largest lender before leaving to join Indian Bank as MD in 2018. There, she successfully oversaw Allahabad Bank's merger into her own bank, making the combined entity the seventh largest public sector bank in the country. The career banker also served as a director on the board of the Life Insurance Corporation of India and National Payments Corporation of India. Since taking over as the NSDL chief in 2021, she has had to put her deep understanding of digital technologies and financial markets to the test in keeping with market regulator SEBI's requisites of better monitoring and efficient implementation. NSDL currently manages over 3.4 million demat accounts with a custody value of over Rs 370 lakh crore. Padmaja has overseen the successful integration of a complex distributed ledger blockchain technology-based platform for debenture security and covenant monitoring. The system captures the whole process, from creation of security to continuous monitoring of covenants by debenture trustees to credit rating of non-convertible securities by the rating agencies.

Padmaja inadvertently became part of a viral incident in 2022 after Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman got up from her seat to offer her a bottle of water while she was speaking at the podium (the NSDL chief had indicated to a bearer that she needed a glass of water). The FM's gesture was much appreciated on social media. The 27-year history of NSDL showcases the trajectory of the institution, how its leaders have shaped it and the institution's impact on the capital markets. Padmaja's tenure so far has been no different, fuelled also by a strong market buzz that the depository is mulling going public. If it does go that way, the regulations require NSDL's founders IDBI Bank and the NSE to reduce their holdings. Padmaja's next big task will be to decide whether NSDL wants to hit the financial markets or look for a strategic partner. ■

–Anilesh S. Mahajan

ACCOMPLISHMENT
First woman to head the country's largest securities depository company, National Securities Depository Ltd (NSDL)



MANDAR DEODHAR

WALK OF LIFE

"Choose your direction, calibrate your pace but keep moving forward"

SEPIA TINTED
Passionate about collecting and preserving old family photographs